



U.S. Department of Homeland Security Enterprise
Department of Homeland Security Employee Performance Plan and Appraisal Form

Part 1. Employee Input *I have reviewed this plan and have been involved in its development.*

Employee Name (Last, First, Middle): TIPTON, MICHAEL B		Appraisal Pd. 10/1/2025 - 9/30/2026
Title: Lead IT Specialist	Supervisory Code: 8 - All Other Positions	Series/Plan/Grade: 2210 - GS - 14
Organization: Threat Hunting		Plan Number: DHS Form 309
Plan Purpose: Annual		
Originally signed by ROLLIE BERRY III on 1/15/2026		
Rating Official's Signature: Electronically signed by LEIDY, MATTHEW GEORGE (Rating Official)		Date: 6/26/2026
Originally signed by Matthew GEORGE Leidy on 1/16/2026		
Employee's Signature: Electronically signed by TIPTON, MICHAEL B		Date: 6/26/2026
Originally signed by MICHAEL B TIPTON on 1/16/2026		

Part 2. Progress Review

Phase: Progress Review 1

Rating Official's Signature: Electronically signed by LEIDY, MATTHEW GEORGE (Rating Official)	Date: 6/26/2026
Employee's Signature: Electronically signed by TIPTON, MICHAEL B	Date: 6/26/2026

Phase: Progress Review 2

Rating Official's Signature: Electronically signed by LEIDY, MATTHEW GEORGE (Rating Official)	Date: 6/26/2026
Employee's Signature: Electronically signed by TIPTON, MICHAEL B	Date: 6/26/2026

Phase: Progress Review 3

Rating Official's Signature: Electronically signed by LEIDY, MATTHEW GEORGE (Rating Official)	Date: 8/13/2026
Employee's Signature: Electronically signed by TIPTON, MICHAEL B	Date: 8/14/2026

Part 3. Rating

Summary Rating Levels:	☐ Unacceptable ☐ Achieved Expectations ☐ Exceeded Expectations ☐ Achieved Excellence
Unacceptable: The employee performed below the "Achieved Expectations" standard; action is required.	
Achieved Expectations: The employee performed as described by the "Achieved Expectations" standard.	
Exceeded Expectations: The employee performed at a level between "Achieved Excellence" standard and the "Achieved Expectations" standard.	
Achieved Excellence: The employee performed as described by the "Achieved Excellence" standard.	

Part 4. Derivation Formula and Calculation of Annual Summary Rating

Performance Element/Performance Element Group	Rating Level	Rating Value	Weight	Score	Summary Level Ranges
Core Competencies					4.5 - 5 = Achieved Excellence 3.5 - 4.49 = Exceeded Expectations 3 - 3.49 = Achieved Expectations 0 - 2.99 = Unacceptable
Performance Element	Rating Level	Rating Value			
CORE COMPETENCY 1: COMMUNICATION *					
CORE COMPETENCY 2: CUSTOMER SERVICE *					
CORE COMPETENCY 3: REPRESENTING THE AGENCY *					
CORE COMPETENCY 4: TEAMWORK AND COOPERATION *					
CORE COMPETENCY 5: TECHNICAL PROFICIENCY *					
Performance Goals					
Performance Element	Rating Level	Rating Value	Weight	Score	
PERFORMANCE GOAL *					
PERFORMANCE GOAL *					
PERFORMANCE GOAL *					

* Denotes Critical Element
 ^ Denotes Overridden Rating
 ✕ Denotes PE not included in Rating Calculations

Part 6. Instructions

Mission Statement: With Honor and Integrity, we will safeguard the American people, our homeland and our values.

Core Competencies Part 7 allows you to view the pre-established, critical core competencies and associated performance standards. Each core competency is critical which means that an Unacceptable determination in any one competency results in an overall Unacceptable Rating. These behavioral competencies were validated by the DHS workforce population. You cannot update or modify any of the information in this section. Supervisors rate employees in each critical core competency in USA Performance. The system will calculate the final summary rating.

Each critical competency is weighted equally and, together, makeup 40% of the overall performance rating. The critical performance goals makeup the other 60% of the overall performance rating and appear under the Part 7 of this document.

- **Achieved Excellence.** The employee performed as described by the "Achieved Excellence" standard.
- **Exceeded Expectations.** The employee performed at a level between "Achieved Excellence" standard and the "Achieved Expectations" standard.
- **Achieved Expectations.** The employee performed as described by the "Achieved Expectations" standard.
- **Unacceptable.** The employee performed below the "Achieved Expectations" standard; action is required.

Performance Goals Part 7 allows entry for up to 5 critical Performance Goals for the employee. Each performance goal is critical, which means that an Unacceptable determination in any one goal results in an overall Unacceptable Rating. If more than 5 Performance Goals need to be added, please refer to your servicing HR specialist. Supervisors rate employees in each performance goal in USA Performance. The system will calculate the final summary rating.

Each critical performance goal must be assigned a share to equal 60% of the overall performance rating. For example, if the employee has 3 critical goals, they might be weighted as follows: 30%, 20%, and 10%. The critical competencies makeup the other 40% of the overall performance rating and appear under Part 7 of this document.

- **Achieved Excellence.** The employee performed as described by the "Achieved Excellence" standard.
- **Exceeded Expectations.** The employee performed at a level between "Achieved Excellence" standard and the "Achieved Expectations" standard.
- **Achieved Expectations.** The employee performed as described by the "Achieved Expectations" standard.
- **Unacceptable.** The employee performed below the "Achieved Expectations" standard; action is required.

For each performance goal, please describe expected performance at the "Achieved Expectations" and "Achieved Excellence" levels. These "performance standards" should include measures such as quality, quantity, timeliness, and/or cost effectiveness.

Summary rating narratives are required for overall ratings at the Unacceptable and Achieved Excellence rating levels.

Part 7. Performance Elements**Core Competencies**

Weight: 40%

CORE COMPETENCY 1: COMMUNICATION☒ **Critical****Strategic Alignment:**

Actively listens and attends to nonverbal cues when responding to the questions, ideas, and concerns of others. Communicates in an influential or persuasive manner, as appropriate. Writes in a clear and concise manner. Orally communicates in a clear and concise manner. Tailors communication (e.g., language, tone, level of specificity) to the audience's level of understanding and to the communication medium.

Achieved Expectations:

Solicits others' input, viewpoints, or questions; addresses various viewpoints and provides clear and organized responses to complex issues, following up to ensure understanding. Shows respect for and carefully considers others' ideas, comments, and questions. Communicates in an influential or persuasive manner, as appropriate. Independently prepares and delivers timely, clear, and concise communications on complex topics. Independently and effectively selects what information to include in communications to best meet the audience's needs. Writes communications that typically require minimal revisions.

Achieved Excellence:

Additions at the Achieved Excellence level: Accurately reads and assesses complex organizational or interpersonal situations and responds effectively. Delivers responses in a confident and compelling manner that frequently persuades the audience to a viewpoint. Tailors communication style (e.g., language, tone, and format) and content to different levels of audiences, properly emphasizing the most critical issues and considering ramifications of communications. Writes communications that rarely require revisions.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**CORE COMPETENCY****1: COMMUNICATION**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence**Rating Levels:**

CORE COMPETENCY 2: CUSTOMER SERVICE☒ **Critical****Strategic Alignment:**

Communicates with customers to understand their needs. Works with customers to set expectations and keeps them informed of issues or problems. Provides timely, flexible, and responsive services to customers.

Achieved Expectations:

Maintains regular contact with customers to understand and anticipate their needs; uses customer feedback to enhance products and services. Works with customers to reach mutually acceptable expectations, timelines, and deliverables for large-scale initiatives. Informs customers of changes, issues, or problems that could affect progress and develops effective solutions to address them. Provides flexible, creative, and responsive service to customers, resulting in high levels of customer satisfaction.

Achieved Excellence:

Additions at the Achieved Excellence level: Proactively develops innovative and useful approaches for improving or expanding products or services. Takes initiative to anticipate and proactively implement effective solutions to prevent problems, thus avoiding gaps in customer expectations and maximizing customer satisfaction.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**CORE COMPETENCY****2: CUSTOMER****SERVICE Rating****Levels:**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence**CORE COMPETENCY 3: REPRESENTING THE AGENCY**☒ **Critical****Strategic Alignment:**

Represents the agency and its interests in interactions with external parties. Ensures that interactions with and information provided to outside parties reflect positively on the agency. Enhances trust and credibility in the agency and its mission through effective professional interactions with others outside the organization. Deals professionally and tactfully with external parties in difficult, tense, or emergency situations.

Achieved Exepectations:

Represents the agency in a professional manner that educates others, protects its interests, and enhances its image and reputation. Takes action to effectively manage difficult, tense, or emergency situations. Engages with others in a manner that earns their respect and helps to advance the agency's goals and objectives.

Achieved Excellence:

Additions at the Achieved Excellence level: Demonstrates exceptional skill in representing the agency; is widely recognized and regularly sought to handle very difficult, sensitive, or visible situations with others. Assumes leadership in handling extremely difficult, tense, or emergency situations; quickly and decisively manages them with a high degree of effectiveness.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**CORE COMPETENCY****3: REPRESENTING THE****AGENCY Rating****Levels:**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Exepectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence

CORE COMPETENCY 4: TEAMWORK AND COOPERATION☒ **Critical****Strategic Alignment:**

Makes positive contributions to achieving team goals. Develops and maintains collaborative working relationships with others. Builds effective partnerships that facilitate working across boundaries, groups, or organizations. Treats everyone respectfully, fairly, and professionally. Works constructively with others to reach mutually acceptable agreements to resolve conflicts.

Achieved Expectations:

Contributes to achieving objectives by demonstrating collaborative behaviors with others and building effective partnerships across organizational boundaries. Independently offers assistance and provides support to advance goals. Deals with everyone fairly, and professionally. Anticipates situations with potential for conflict and takes effective measures to minimize escalation. Fosters an environment in which all team members are encouraged to speak openly, freely, and constructively, resulting in the effective resolution of conflicts.

Achieved Excellence:

Additions at the Achieved Excellence level: Collaborates beyond what is expected resulting in high-impact contributions. Skillfully develops productive relationships and networks that advance goals. Fosters a climate of trust.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**CORE COMPETENCY****4: TEAMWORK AND****COOPERATION Rating****Levels:**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence

CORE COMPETENCY 5: TECHNICAL PROFICIENCY☒ **Critical****Strategic Alignment:**

Demonstrates and applies relevant knowledge and skills to perform work in accordance with applicable guidelines. Uses appropriate and available technology or tools to perform work activities. Acquires, develops, and maintains relevant and appropriate job skills through training or other opportunities for learning and development. Stays up-to-date on developments related to own work. Demonstrates an understanding of the organization's mission, functions, and systems. Collects relevant information that is needed to identify and address problems or issues. Analyzes and integrates information to identify issues and draw sound conclusions. Identifies and evaluates alternative solutions to problems. Makes sound, well-informed, and timely decisions or recommendations. Identifies and utilizes innovative or creative methods and solutions to accomplish work, as appropriate. Maintains an awareness of available resources and the process for acquiring resources. Identifies and advocates for resources required to accomplish work activities or projects. Makes effective and efficient use of available resources. Safeguards available resources to prevent fraud, waste, and abuse.

Achieved Expectations:

Successfully applies advanced knowledge and skills (including use of technology and tools) to perform a wide range of work activities, such as those that are highly complex, visible, or organization-wide. Effectively seeks and uses formal or informal feedback on own performance to enhance knowledge and skills that facilitate achieving results. Demonstrates a thorough understanding of the applicable organization's mission, functions, values, the interrelationships between various units and organizations, and relevant policies/procedures (to include, as appropriate, responsibilities toward the protection of classified national security information) and how these affect the agency; carries out complex work in accordance with these. Demonstrates in-depth knowledge of the resources available to the work unit, and ensures that resources are distributed and utilized in a highly efficient manner. As required, prepares complex project or activity resource plans and effectively defends resource requirements. Identifies and collects key information that is needed to provide a comprehensive understanding of the situation. Effectively analyzes and integrates complex information to identify important issues and assumptions, assess impact, and draw logical conclusions. Anticipates and identifies alternative solutions for complex problems and makes sound and timely decisions; considers alternative courses of action and chooses an effective option.

Achieved Excellence:

Additions at the Achieved Excellence level: Uses depth or breadth of expertise to handle the most complex and difficult technical assignments at this level, performing cutting-edge or precedent-setting work. Continually broadens and enhances expertise, resulting in performing the most complex work activities and making contributions that significantly advance key organizational goals and objectives. Devises creative and resourceful approaches to leverage available resources, thereby maximizing achievement of outcomes. Identifies and uses effective methods to optimize efficiency in gathering information. Develops highly effective solutions or decisions for unusual or more complex issues, carefully considering both short- and long-term consequences. Rapidly makes insightful connections between disparate pieces of information and identifies issues with larger implications and significance.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:

**CORE COMPETENCY
5: TECHNICAL
PROFICIENCY Rating
Levels:**

☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence**Performance Goals**

Weight: 60%

PERFORMANCE GOAL☒ **Critical**Weight: 25
%**Strategic Alignment:****Threat Hunting FY26 Performance Goal:**

Threat Hunting FY26 Performance Goal

Achieved Expectations:

- Contribute regularly (at least monthly) to status updates, reports, and/or data that help the subdivision track, measure, and communicate its performance and achievements. Follow supervisor guidance regarding cadence and reporting mechanism(s).
- Remain informed of and follow DHS, CISA, CSD, and TH organizational policies. Follow all TH Policy and Guidance regarding operational and programmatic decision making. If needed, raise areas of concern or risk to supervisor.
- Complete all CISA mandatory training on time. • Complete all TH mandatory staff surveys on time.
- Maintain an active certificate for the Federal Acquisition Certification (FAC) Training Course 043 - Ethics & Procurement Integrity. Provide certificate to direct supervisor by August 1, 2026.

Achieved Excellence:

In addition to the "Achieved Expectations" requirements,

- Identify at least three innovative improvements (e.g., to a service, product, initiative, process, and/or technology) for the subdivision. Submit a written document to your supervisor outlining the gap to be addressed and the significance of the proposed innovation(s).
- Contribute to advancements in TH organizational maturity. For example, develop a standard operating procedure (SOP), work instruction (WI), or similar product relevant to your role and obtain supervisor approval.
- Be recognized by your supervisor or another TH leader for an achievement or significant contribution. The recognition could include an award nomination, "shout out," or "employee spotlight" in a written TH, CSD, or CISA publication, or equivalent.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**PERFORMANCE GOAL
Rating Levels:**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence**PERFORMANCE GOAL**☒ **Critical**Weight: 35
%**Strategic Alignment:****Engineering & Operations Services (EOS) Branch Goal:**

Redesign the TEN network based on zero-trust principles, redesign the security framework for AWS, document the current TEN network architecture, and conduct resource planning to ensure a successful implementation. Develop a comprehensive service map of all Agency tools and applications across all Agency networks, ensuring seamless integration, efficient resource allocation, and improved user experience.

Achieved Expectations:**Operational Impact:**

- Contribute to operationally impactful effort that provides mission critical capabilities.
- Contribute to the progression of five (5) TECHMAN tickets

- Document all necessary updates and contributions in TECHMAN and JANUS tickets.
- Provide all necessary documents to include project plans, evaluations, decision memo, etc.

Innovation:

- Collaborate with TH and/or CISA stakeholders to advanced and communicate our direction for Artificial Intelligence(AI), Development, Engineering, and/or automation.
- Attend three (3) meetings and develop three (3) processes/policies that advance one of the above efforts.
- Document contributions and successes for meeting attendance with above efforts.
- Document approved processes and/or policies actively working in Production environments.

Service Map Foundation:

- Develop, document, and collaborate with BOB for plan of Service Map 2.0 and gather approval from Branch Leadership.
- Categorize and group all similar services into logical categories by Q4 FY26.

Achieved Excellence:**Operational Impact:**

- Lead an operationally impactful effort that provides mission critical capabilities.
- Lead and complete five(5) TECHMAN tickets
- Document all necessary updates and contributions in TECHMAN and JANUS tickets.
- Provide all necessary documents to include project plans, evaluations, decision memo, etc.

Innovation:

- Lead and complete an effort, approved by branch leadership, with TH and/or CISA stakeholders to advance our direction for Artificial Intelligence (AI), development, system engineering, and/or automation.
- Host meetings and develop processes/policies that advance one of the above efforts.
- Document project plan, timeline, and outcomes for effort
- Document approved processes and/or policies implemented into Production environments.
- Documented metrics and feedback to determine output value and analyst usage.

Service Map Optimization:

- Complete Service Map 2.0 fully implemented and provide access to Threat Hunting Branches.
- The service map contains a lifecycle for updating and tracking responsible parties by end of Q4 FY25.
- A report on the current state of the service map and its implications for resource allocation and user experience must be generated and presented to TH senior management by the end of Q4 FY25.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**PERFORMANCE GOAL****Rating Levels:**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence**PERFORMANCE GOAL**☒ **Critical**Weight: 40
%**Strategic Alignment:****Capability Development & Engineering (CDE) Section Goal:**

Establish a robust CDE section that effectively collaborates with stakeholders to deliver value-added capabilities that meet their needs.

Achieved Expectations:

1. Enable, coordinate, or contribute to 1 CI/CD pipeline automation supporting incoming or current product requests, increasing repeatability of analytic functions, builds, validations, and deployments by Q4 FY26; contribute to or review the implementation of 2 quality gates (e.g. tests, scanning, secrets management, documentation of repeatable processes, etc).
2. Contribute or participate in stakeholder engagements (>= 2 per TH branch / per stakeholder section or analyst group by end of FY26) or project-specific meetings (e.g. DFIR-IRIS, S&T projects, etc) to build an understanding of needs, pain points, roles, or expectations, and drive continuous improvement of technologies and services.
3. Contribute to the design, delivery, and operationalization of stakeholder-aligned solutions (target >= 2); integrate capability improvements into existing environments; coordinate analyst notebook workflows on agency analytics platforms and support the build-out of data pipelines, with documentation/demos/runbooks that enable adoption and strengthen competency.
4. Contribute to or participate in 2 meetings on the development of the TH Service Catalog, help review at least 10 catalog entries; deliver a user-friendly interface for stakeholder access; and help begin establishing a clear maintenance lifecycle with designated responsible parties to keep all artifacts current and accessible.
5. Complete one targeted growth activity (training course or hands-on use of a new tool) related to a TH function or technology.

Achieved Excellence:

1. Scale and standardize CI/CD across 2 or more capabilities; drive cross-functional delivery, provide technical stewardship of at least 4 patterns or quality gates (e.g., automated tests, security scans, secrets checks, staging validations, protected-branch approvals, etc.), and lead the adoption of proactive security measures (e.g. automated scanning, documentation of repeatable processes).
2. Attend and contribute to at least 5 touchpoints for each stakeholder section or project-specific meetings (e.g. DFIR-IRIS, S&T projects, etc) and gather expectations, constraints, and requirements by the end of FY26; use these insights to drive continuous improvement of technologies and services.
3. Drive cross-functional delivery, provide technical stewardship of integration patterns or quality gates, or lead the development of 1 high-value solution; standardize integration and operational handoffs with documented processes and deployment criteria; increase tool adoption and implementation of performance metrics (e.g., usage, reliability, cycle time); and embed proactive security engineering (least-privilege, automated scanning/patch gates) that measurably improves reliability and reduces risk.
4. Publish the Threat Hunting Service Catalog (leadership-approved); attend 5 service catalog meetings; contribute to, refine, or review 20 unique catalog entries; contribute feedback on maintenance lifecycle plans; and play a part in shaping efforts for TH-wide adoption, usage, and feedback mechanisms.
5. Complete at least 2 targeted growth activities (training courses or hands-on use of new tools) related to a TH function or technology.

Employee Element Self-Accomplishment Narrative:**PERFORMANCE GOAL****Rating Levels:**☐ Unacceptable☐ Achieved Expectations☐ Exceeded Expectations☐ Achieved Excellence

Part 9. Employee Self-Accomplishment Narrative

Part 10. For Agency Use